

Identity Leadership Experience

Vice President – African Student Association (ASA) & International Student Association (ISA)

By Joel Tchouke

Throughout my time at Minnesota State University, Mankato, leadership has played a central role in my personal and professional development. During the 2023–2024 academic year, I had the opportunity to serve as Vice President of both the African Student Association (ASA) and the International Student Association (ISA). Taking on leadership roles in two organizations simultaneously was both challenging and deeply rewarding. These organizations brought together students from a wide range of cultural backgrounds, and they aimed to create spaces where people could celebrate their identities, build community, and learn from one another.

When I accepted these positions, I knew the responsibilities would be significant. As Vice President, my role involved supporting the president in guiding the organization, helping coordinate major cultural events, facilitating communication between board members, and ensuring that our initiatives aligned with the mission of our organizations. However, beyond these formal responsibilities, the role also required adaptability, patience, and the ability to collaborate with individuals who brought different perspectives and experiences to the table.

One of the most meaningful experiences during my time with the African Student Association was helping organize **African Night**, one of the organization's largest cultural events of the year. African Night is designed to celebrate African cultures through music, dance, food, and performances. It requires months of preparation and coordination between board members, performers, volunteers, and the university.

During the early planning stages of the event, our leadership team encountered an important challenge. Members of the executive board had different visions for how the event should be structured. Some members wanted the event to emphasize traditional cultural performances that reflected historical practices and heritage. Others believed that including modern African music and contemporary cultural expressions would help the event connect with a broader audience on campus.

At first, these differing perspectives created tension within the group. Each member felt strongly about representing African culture in an authentic way. As Vice President, I recognized that my role was not to impose a solution but to create space for meaningful discussion. I encouraged each

member to explain their perspective and the reasoning behind it. By listening carefully and facilitating respectful conversation, we were able to move away from disagreement and toward collaboration.

Eventually, we reached a compromise that allowed the event to include both traditional and modern elements. The final program included traditional dances and cultural presentations, while also incorporating contemporary music performances and modern African cultural influences. The result was an event that reflected the diversity and evolution of African culture. Seeing students from many different backgrounds attend the event and celebrate African culture together made the months of preparation incredibly rewarding.

My leadership role within the International Student Association involved similar responsibilities but with an even broader intercultural focus. ISA works to bring together students from many different countries and cultural backgrounds, helping them feel welcomed and supported within the university community.

One of the most significant initiatives organized through ISA was the **International Festival**, a large campus event that celebrated global cultures through performances, cultural booths, and community interaction. Planning this event required extensive collaboration with volunteers and student groups representing many different countries.

One moment from the International Festival stands out as a defining leadership experience for me. Only a few hours before the event was scheduled to begin, one of the scheduled performers informed us that they would not be able to attend due to an unexpected issue. This created immediate concern among the leadership team because the performance schedule had already been carefully planned.

At that moment, the room became tense. Many team members were worried that the schedule would fall apart or that the audience would notice the gap. Instead of allowing the stress of the situation to escalate, our leadership team quickly shifted into problem-solving mode. I worked with other board members to reorganize the performance schedule while communicating with performers who were already present. Several performers generously agreed to extend their performances to fill the open time slot.

Through teamwork and quick decision-making, we were able to adjust the program without disrupting the flow of the event. Most attendees never realized that the schedule had been altered at the last minute. That experience taught me that leadership often involves remaining calm under pressure and trusting the collective strength of a team.

Another important aspect of my leadership experience was learning how to collaborate effectively with other executive board members. Each member played a unique role within the organization. The president typically focused on external communication and long-term strategy, while I often

handled operational coordination and internal communication. The secretary helped keep our meetings organized and documented decisions that guided future planning, while the treasurer ensured that our events remained financially sustainable.

Working with such a diverse and talented group allowed me to observe how different leadership styles and strengths could complement one another. It reinforced the idea that leadership is not about one person controlling the direction of an organization, but about multiple individuals contributing their strengths toward a shared goal.

Another significant challenge during this time was balancing leadership responsibilities with my academic workload. During one semester, I was enrolled in **18 credits**, including some of the most demanding courses in my engineering program. Managing coursework while simultaneously helping coordinate large events often felt overwhelming.

I remember one particular evening during the preparation for African Night when I was studying for midterm exams in the library. At the same time, my phone kept receiving messages from board members about last-minute logistical details for the event. In that moment, I felt exhausted and questioned whether I had taken on too much responsibility. I even began drafting an email to step down from my leadership roles.

However, I paused before sending that message and reflected on the reason I had chosen to become involved in these organizations in the first place. These groups were creating spaces where students from many different backgrounds could connect and celebrate their cultures. I realized that the work we were doing mattered not only to me but also to the broader campus community.

Instead of stepping down, I decided to rely more on my team. I began delegating responsibilities more effectively and trusting other board members to take ownership of certain tasks. This shift allowed our team to function more collaboratively and reminded me that leadership is not about carrying every burden alone.

Through these experiences, I began to develop a deeper understanding of what leadership truly means. Before taking on these roles, I often associated leadership with organization, decision-making, and responsibility. While those elements are certainly part of leadership, I learned that the most important aspects of leadership involve listening, empathy, and collaboration.

One of the most important lessons I learned was the value of **active listening**. During the planning of African Night, I realized that effective leadership requires understanding the perspectives of others before attempting to guide a decision. When board members disagreed about the direction of the event, listening carefully allowed me to understand the cultural values behind their

perspectives. This understanding made it possible for us to find a solution that respected everyone's input.

Another lesson I gained involved recognizing the strengths of others. My **StrengthsFinder results**—Competition, Restorative, Analytical, Futuristic, and Ideation—shaped how I approached leadership challenges.

My **Restorative** strength helped me approach problems with a solution-oriented mindset. When conflicts or unexpected challenges arose, I focused on identifying the root cause of the issue and working collaboratively to resolve it.

My **Analytical** strength helped me evaluate our events and organizational strategies. I often reviewed attendance numbers, participant feedback, and previous planning approaches to improve future initiatives.

My **Ideation** strength also played an important role in developing creative programming for our organizations. One example was the **Africa Unplugged panel discussion**, which we organized to challenge stereotypes about African cultures and highlight the diversity of experiences across the continent. The discussion created meaningful dialogue among students and encouraged many attendees to reconsider assumptions they had previously held.

Perhaps the most important realization from these leadership experiences was understanding that leadership is not about controlling outcomes but about **empowering others to contribute**. Some of the most successful moments in our organizations occurred when team members felt confident enough to share their ideas and take ownership of projects.

Balancing leadership with academic responsibilities also taught me resilience and self-awareness. There were moments when the pressure felt overwhelming, but those challenges forced me to improve my time management, prioritize responsibilities, and trust the people around me. Learning to ask for help and rely on my team was an important step in my growth as a leader.

Looking ahead, the leadership lessons I gained from my experiences in ASA and ISA will continue to influence how I approach both my professional career and my involvement in future communities.

As I pursue a career in engineering, I know that collaboration will be essential. Engineering projects often involve teams composed of individuals with different technical backgrounds, cultural perspectives, and problem-solving approaches. The leadership experiences I gained in these organizations taught me that successful collaboration requires more than technical expertise. It requires empathy, clear communication, and the ability to create environments where people feel comfortable sharing ideas.

I also plan to continue fostering inclusive communities wherever I go. The cultural events we organized demonstrated how powerful it can be when people from different backgrounds come together to celebrate their identities and learn from one another. These experiences reinforced my belief that diversity strengthens communities and encourages innovation.

Most importantly, these experiences helped shape my personal philosophy of leadership. I now understand that leadership is not about authority or recognition. Instead, it is about creating opportunities for others to grow, collaborate, and contribute meaningfully.

Serving as Vice President of both the African Student Association and the International Student Association allowed me to grow not only as a leader but also as a person. I became more confident in my ability to guide teams, more patient in listening to different perspectives, and more aware of the importance of collaboration.

These lessons will continue to guide my leadership journey in the future. Whether in engineering teams, community organizations, or professional environments, I hope to carry forward the same commitment to collaboration, inclusivity, and shared success that I developed through these experiences.